

Frenchwoman might have wondered why her lady took a pair of riding breeches and no further equine equipment.

Arrayed in riding breeches, rubber-soled shoes, and a dark-coloured pullover, Bundle was ready for the fray. She glanced at the time. As yet, it was only half-past twelve. Too early by far. Whatever was going to happen would not happen for some time yet. The occupants of the house must all be given time to get off to sleep. Half-past one was the time fixed by Bundle for the start of operations.

She switched off her light and sat down by the window to wait. Punctually at the appointed moment, she rose, pushed up the sash and swung her leg over the sill. The night was a fine one, cold and still. There was starlight but no moon.

She found the descent very easy. Bundle and her two sisters had run wild in the park at Chimneys as small children, and they could all climb like cats. Bundle arrived on a flower-bed, rather breathless, but quite unscathed.

She paused a minute to take stock of her plans. She knew that the rooms occupied by the Air Minister and his secretary were in the west wing; that was the opposite side of the house from where Bundle was now standing. A terrace ran along the south and west side of the house, ending abruptly against a walled fruit garden.

Bundle stepped out of her flower-bed and turned the corner of the house to where the terrace began on the south side. She crept very quietly along it, keeping close to the shadow of the house. But, as she reached the second corner, she got a shock, for a man was standing there, with the clear intention of barring her way.

The next instant she had recognized him.

'Superintendent Battle! You did give me a fright!'

'That's what I'm here for,' said the Superintendent pleasantly.

Bundle looked at him. It struck her now, as so often before, how remarkably little camouflage there was about him. He was large and solid and noticeable. He was, somehow, very English. But of one thing Bundle was quite sure. Superintendent Battle was no fool.

'What are you really doing here?' she asked, still in a whisper.

'Just seeing,' said Battle, 'that nobody's about who shouldn't be.'

'Oh?' said Bundle, rather taken aback.

'You, for instance, Lady Eileen. I don't suppose you usually take a walk at this time of night.'

'Do you mean,' said Bundle slowly, 'that you want me to go back?'

Superintendent Battle nodded approvingly.

'You're very quick, Lady Eileen. That's just what I do mean. Did you—er—come out of a door, or the window?'

'The window. It's easy as anything climbing down this ivy.'

Superintendent Battle looked up at it thoughtfully.

'Yes,' he said. 'I should say it would be.'

'And you want me to go back?' said Bundle. 'I'm rather sick about that. I wanted to go round on to the west terrace.'

'Perhaps you won't be the only one who'll want to do that,' said Battle.

'Nobody could miss seeing you,' said Bundle rather spitefully.

The Superintendent seemed rather pleased than otherwise.

'I hope they won't,' he said. '*No unpleasantness*. That's my motto. And if you'll excuse me, Lady Eileen, I think it's time you were going back to bed.'

The firmness of his tone admitted of no parley. Rather crestfallen, Bundle retraced her steps. She was half-way up the ivy when a sudden idea occurred to her, and she nearly relaxed her grip and fell.

Supposing Superintendent Battle suspected *her*.

There had been something—yes, surely there had been something in his manner that vaguely suggested the idea. She couldn't help laughing as she crawled over the sill into her bedroom. Fancy the solid Superintendent suspecting *her*!

Though she had so far obeyed Battle's orders as to return to her room, Bundle had no intention of going to bed and sleeping. Nor did she think that Battle had really intended her to do so. He was not a man to expect impossibilities. And to remain quiescent when something daring and exciting might be going on was a sheer impossibility to Bundle.

She glanced at her watch. It was ten minutes to two. After a moment or two of irresolution, she cautiously opened her door. Not a sound. Everything was still and peaceful. She stole cautiously along the passage.

Once she halted, thinking she heard a board creak somewhere, but then convinced that she was mistaken, she went on again. She was now in the

main corridor, making her way to the west wing. She reached the angle of intersection and peered cautiously round—then she stared in blank surprise.

The watcher's post was empty. Jimmy Thesiger was not there.

Bundle stared in complete amazement. What had happened? Why had Jimmy left his post? What did it mean?

And at that moment she heard a clock strike two.

She was still standing there, debating what to do next, when suddenly her heart gave a leap and then seemed to stand still.

The door handle of Terence O'Rourke's room was slowly turning.

Bundle watched, fascinated. But the door did not open. Instead the knob returned slowly to its original position. What did it mean?

Suddenly Bundle came to a resolution. Jimmy, for some unknown reason, had deserted his post. She must get hold of Bill.

Quickly and noiselessly, Bundle fled along the way she had come. She burst unceremoniously into Bill's room.

'Bill, wake up! Oh, do wake up!'

It was an urgent whisper she sent forth, but there came no response to it. 'Bill,' breathed Bundle.

Impatiently she switched on the lights, and then stood dumfounded.

The room was empty, and the bed had not even been slept in.

Where then was Bill?

Suddenly she caught her breath. *This was not Bill's room.* The dainty negligé thrown over a chair, the feminine knick-knacks on the dressing-table, the black velvet evening dress thrown carelessly over a chair—Of course, in her haste she had mistaken the doors. This was the Countess Radzky's room.

But where, oh, where, was the Countess?

And just as Bundle was asking herself this question, the silence of the night was suddenly broken, and in no uncertain manner.

The clamour came from below. In an instant Bundle had sped out of the Countess's room and downstairs. The sounds came from the library—a violent crashing of chairs being overturned.

Bundle rattled vainly at the library door. It was locked. But she could clearly hear the struggle that was going on within—the panting and scuffling, curses in manly tones, the occasional crash as some light piece of furniture came into the line of battle.

Chapter XIX

Bundle's Adventures

BUNDLE Brent was a resourceful girl—she was also a girl of imagination. She had foreseen that Bill, if not Jimmy, would make objections to her participation in the possible dangers of the night. It was not Bundle's idea to waste time in argument. She had laid her own plans and made her own arrangements. A glance from her bedroom window shortly before dinner had been highly satisfactory. She had known that the gray walls of the Abbey were plentifully adorned with ivy, but the ivy outside her window was particularly solid looking and would present no difficulties to one of her athletic propensities.

She had no fault to find with Bill's and Jimmy's arrangements as far as they went. But in her opinion they did not go far enough. She offered no criticism, because she intended to see to that side of things herself. Briefly, while Jimmy and Bill were devoting themselves to the inside of the Abbey, Bundle intended to devote her attentions to the outside.

Her own meek acquiescence in the tame rôle assigned to her gave her an infinity of pleasure, though she wondered scornfully how either of the two men could be so easily deceived. Bill, of course, had never been famous for scintillating brain power. On the other hand, he knew, or should know, his Bundle. And she considered that Jimmy Thesiger, though only slightly acquainted with her, ought to have known better than to imagine that she could be so easily and summarily disposed of.

Once in the privacy of her own room, Bundle set rapidly to work. First she discarded her evening dress and the negligible trifle which she wore beneath it, and started again, so to speak, from the foundations. Bundle had not brought her maid with her, and she herself had packed. Otherwise, the puzzled

The minutes went past... There it was again. The creak of a board... But it came from downstairs somewhere. There it was again! A slight, ominous creak. Somebody was moving stealthily about the house.

Jimmy sprang noiselessly to his feet. He crept silently to the head of the staircase. Everything seemed perfectly quiet. Yet he was quite certain he had really heard that stealthy sound. It was not imagination.

Very quietly and cautiously he crept down the staircase, Leopold clasped tightly in his right hand. Not a sound in the big hall. If he had been correct in assuming that the muffled sound came from directly beneath him, then it must have come from the library.

Jimmy stole to the door of it, listened, but heard nothing; then, suddenly flinging open the door, he switched on the lights.

Nothing! The big room was flooded with light. But it was empty.

Jimmy frowned.

'I could have sworn —' he murmured to himself.

The library was a large room with three windows which opened on to the terrace. Jimmy strode across the room. The middle window was unlatched.

He opened it and stepped out on the terrace, looking from end to end of it. Nothing!

'Looks all right,' he murmured to himself. 'And yet—'

He remained for a minute lost in thought. Then he stepped back into the library. Crossing to the door, he locked it and put the key in his pocket. Then he switched off the light. He stood for a minute listening, then crossed softly to the open window and stood there, Leopold ready in his hand.

Was there, or was there not, a soft patter of feet along the terrace? No—his imagination. He grasped Leopold tightly and stood listening...

In the distance a stable clock chimed two.

And then, sinister and distinct, breaking the peace of the night for good and all, two shots in rapid succession.

where the corridor ran into the main gallery formed a perfect vantage ground. There was no other way into the west wing, and anyone going to or from it could not fail to be seen. One electric light was still on.

Jimmy ensconced himself comfortably, crossed his legs and waited. Leopold lay in readiness across his knee.

He glanced at his watch. It was twenty minutes to one—just an hour since the household had retired to rest. Not a sound broke the stillness, except for the far-off ticking of a clock somewhere.

Somehow or other, Jimmy did not much care for that sound. It recalled things. Gerald Wade—and those seven ticking clocks on the mantelpiece..Whose hand had placed them there, and why? He shivered.

It was a creepy business, this waiting. He didn't wonder that things happened at spiritualistic séances. Sitting in the gloom, one got all worked up—ready to start at the least sound. And unpleasant thoughts came crowding in on a fellow.

Ronny Devereux! Ronny Devereux and Gerry Wade! Both young, both full of life and energy; ordinary, jolly, healthy young men. And now, where were they? Dank earth...worms getting them...Ugh! why couldn't he put these horrible thoughts out of his mind?

He looked again at his watch. Twenty minutes past one only. How the time crawled.

Extraordinary girl, Bundle! Fancy having the nerve and the daring actually to get into the midst of that Seven Dials place. Why hadn't he had the nerve and the initiative to think of that? He supposed because the thing *was* so fantastic.

Nº 7. Who the hell could Nº 7 be? Was he, perhaps, in the house at this minute? Disguised as a servant. He couldn't, surely, be one of the guests. No, that was impossible. But then, the whole thing was impossible. If he hadn't believed Bundle to be essentially truthful—well, he would have thought she had invented the whole thing.

He yawned. Queer, to feel sleepy, and yet at the same time strung up. He looked again at his watch. Ten minutes to two. Time was getting on.

And then, suddenly, he held his breath and leaned forward, listening. He had heard something.

Bill looked at him reproachfully.

'What the hell do you want to go and make a chap uncomfortable for?' he demanded.

'You're only getting your own back,' said Jimmy. 'Toddle along.'

But Bill lingered. He stood uncomfortably, first on one foot and then on the other.

'Look here,' he said.

'Yes?'

'What I mean to say is—well, I mean you'll be all right and all that, won't you? It's all very well ragging, but when I think of poor old Gerry—and then poor old Ronny—'

Jimmy gazed at him in exasperation. Bill was one of those who undoubtedly meant well, but the result of his efforts would not be described as heartening.

'I see,' he remarked, 'that I shall have to show you Leopold.'

He slipped his hand into the pocket of the dark blue suit into which he had just changed and held out something for Bill's inspection.

'A real, genuine, blue-nosed automatic,' he said with modest pride.

'No, I say,' Bill said. 'Is it really?'

He was undoubtedly impressed.

'Stevens, my man, got him for me. Warranted clean and methodical in his habits. You press the button and Leopold does the rest.'

'Oh!' said Bill. 'I say, Jimmy?'

'Yes?'

'Be careful, won't you? I mean, don't go loosing that thing off at anybody.

Pretty awkward if you shot old Digby walking in his sleep.'

'That's all right,' said Jimmy. 'Naturally, I want to get value out of Leopold now I've bought him, but I'll curb my bloodthirsty instincts as far as possible.'

'Well, night-night,' said Bill for the fourteenth time, and this time really did depart.

Jimmy was left alone to take up his vigil.

Sir Stanley Digby occupied a room at the extremity of the west wing. A bathroom adjoined it on one side, and on the other a communicating door led into a smaller room, which was tenanted by Mr Terence O'Rourke. The doors of these three rooms gave on to a short corridor. The watcher had a simple task. A chair placed inconspicuously in the shadow of an oak press just

Chapter XX

Loraine's Adventures

LORAINÉ Wade sat up in bed and switched on the light. It was exactly ten minutes to one. She had gone to bed early—at half-past nine. She possessed the useful art of being able to wake herself up at the required time, so she had been able to enjoy some hours of refreshing sleep.

Two dogs slept in the room with her, and one of these now raised his head and looked at her inquiringly.

'Quiet, Lurcher,' said Loraine, and the big animal put his head down again obediently, watching her from between his shaggy eyelashes.

It is true that Bundle had once doubted the meekness of Loraine Wade, but that brief moment of suspicion had passed. Loraine had seemed so entirely reasonable, so willing to be kept out of everything.

And yet, if you studied the girl's face, you saw that there was strength of purpose in the small, resolute jaw and the lips that closed together so firmly.

Loraine rose and dressed herself in a tweed coat and skirt. Into one pocket of the coat she dropped an electric torch. Then she opened the drawer of her dressing-table and took out a small ivory-handled pistol—almost a toy in appearance. She had bought it the day before at Harrods and she was very pleased with it.

She gave a final glance round the room to see if she had forgotten anything, and at that moment the big dog rose and came over to her, looking up at her with pleading eyes and wagging his tail.

Loraine shook her head.

'No, Lurcher. Can't go. Missus can't take you. Got to stay here and be a good boy.'

She dropped a kiss on the dog's head, made him lie down on his rug again, and then slipped noiselessly out of the room, closing the door behind her.

She let herself out of the house by a side door and made her way round to the garage, where her little two-seater car was in readiness. There was a gentle slope, and she let the car run silently down it, not starting the engine till she was some way from the house. Then she glanced at the watch on her arm and pressed her foot down on the accelerator.

She left the car at a spot she had previously marked down. There was a gap there in the fencing that she could easily get through. A few minutes later, slightly muddily, Lorraine stood inside the grounds of Wyvern Abbey.

As noiselessly as possible, she made her way towards the venerable ivy-covered building. In the distance a stable clock chimed two.

Lorraine's heart beat faster as she drew near to the terrace. There was no one about—no sign of life anywhere. Everything seemed peaceful and undisturbed. She reached the terrace and stood there, looking about her.

Suddenly, without the least warning, something from above fell with a flop almost at her feet. Lorraine stooped to pick it up. It was a brown paper packet, loosely wrapped. Holding it, Lorraine looked up.

There was an open window just above her head, and even as she looked a leg swung over it and a man began to climb down the ivy.

Lorraine waited for no more. She took to her heels and ran, still clasping the brown paper packet.

Behind her, the noise of a struggle suddenly broke out. A hoarse voice: 'Lemme go'; another that she knew well: 'Not if I know it—ah, you would, would you?'

Still Lorraine ran—blindly, as though panic-stricken—right round the corner of the terrace—and slap into the arms of a large, solidly built man.

'There, there,' said Superintendent Bartle kindly.

Lorraine was struggling to speak.

'Oh, quick—oh, quick! They're killing each other. Oh, do be quick!'

There was a sharp crack of a revolver shot—and then another.

Superintendent Bartle started to run. Lorraine followed. Back round the corner of the terrace and along to the library window. The window was open.

Bartle stooped and switched on an electric torch. Lorraine was close beside him, peering over his shoulder. She gave a little sobbing gasp.

Chapter XVIII

Jimmy's Adventures



OUR chronicle must here split into three separate and distinct portions. The night was to prove an eventful one and each of the three persons involved saw it from his or her own individual angle.

We will begin with that pleasant and engaging youth, Mr Jimmy Thesiger, at a moment when he has at last exchanged final good-nights with his fellow conspirator, Bill Eversleigh.

'Don't forget,' said Bill, '3 A.M. If you're still alive, that is,' he added kindly.

'I may be an ass,' said Jimmy, with rancorous remembrance of the remark Bundle had repeated to him, 'but I'm not nearly so much of an ass as I look.'

'That's what you said about Gerry Wade,' said Bill slowly. 'Do you remember? And that very night he—'

'Shut up, you damned fool,' said Jimmy. 'Haven't you got *any* tact?'

'Of course I've got tact,' said Bill. 'I'm a budding diplomatist. All diplomats have tact.'

'Ah!' said Jimmy. 'You must be still in what they call the larval stage.'

'I can't get over Bundle,' said Bill, reverting abruptly to a former topic. 'I should certainly have said that she'd be—well, difficult. Bundle's improved. She's improved very much.'

'That's what your Chief was saying,' said Jimmy. 'He said he was agreeably surprised.'

'I thought Bundle was laying it on a bit thick myself,' said Bill. 'But Codders is such an ass he'd swallow anything. Well, night-night. I expect you'll have a bit of a job waking me when the time comes—but stick to it.'

'It won't be much good if you've taken a leaf out of Gerry Wade's book,' said Jimmy maliciously.

'So did I,' said Jimmy. 'It staggered me.'

'She's got some sense, Bundle has. She knows when a thing's plumb impossible. I say, oughtn't we to have some lethal weapons? Chaps usually do when they're going on this sort of stunt.'

'I have a blue-nosed automatic,' said Jimmy with gentle pride. 'It weighs several pounds and looks most murderous. I'll lend it to you when the time comes.'

Bill looked at him with respect and envy.

'What made you think of getting that?' he said.

'I don't know,' said Jimmy carelessly. 'It just came to me.'

'I hope we shan't go and shoot the wrong person,' said Bill with some anxiety.

'That would be unfortunate,' said Mr Thesiger gravely.

On the threshold of the window lay Jimmy Thesiger in what looked like a pool of blood. His right arm lay dangling in a curious position.

Lorraine gave a sharp cry.

'He's dead,' she wailed. 'Oh, Jimmy—Jimmy—he's dead!'

'Now, now,' said Superintendent Battle soothingly, 'don't you take on so. The young gentleman isn't dead, I'll be bound. See if you can find the lights and turn them on.'

Lorraine obeyed. She stumbled across the room, found the switch by the door and pressed it down. The room was flooded with light. Superintendent Battle uttered a sigh of relief.

'It's all right—he's only shot in the right arm. He's fainted through loss of blood. Come and give me a hand with him.'

There was a pounding on the library door. Voices were heard, asking, expostulating, demanding.

Lorraine looked doubtfully at it.

'Shall I—'

'No hurry,' said Battle. 'We'll let them in presently. You come and give me a hand.'

Lorraine came obediently. The Superintendent had produced a large, clean pocket-handkerchief and was neatly bandaging the wounded man's arm. Lorraine helped him.

'He'll be all right,' said the Superintendent. 'Don't you worry. As many lives as cats, these young fellows. It wasn't the loss of blood knocked him out either. He must have caught his head a crack on the floor as he fell.'

Outside the knocking on the door had become tremendous. The voice of George Lomax, furiously upraised, came loud and distinct:

'Who is in there? Open the door at once.'

Superintendent Battle sighed.

'I suppose we shall have to,' he said. 'A pity.'

His eyes darted round, taking in the scene. An automatic lay by Jimmy's side. The Superintendent picked it up gingerly, holding it very delicately, and examined it. He grunted and laid it on the table. Then he stepped across and unlocked the door.

Several people almost fell into the room. Nearly everybody said something at the same minute. George Lomax, spluttering with obdurate words which refused to come with sufficient fluency, exclaimed:

'The—the—the meaning of this? Ah! It's you, Superintendent. What's happened? I say—what has—happened?'

Bill Everleigh said: 'My God! Old Jimmy!' and stared at the limp figure on the ground.

Lady Coote, clad in a resplendent purple dressing-gown, cried out: 'The poor boy!' and swept past Superintendent Battle to bend over the prostrate Jimmy in a motherly fashion.

Bundle said: 'Lorraine!'

Herr Eberhard said: 'Gott im Himmel!' and other words of that nature.

Sir Stanley Digby said: 'My God, what's all this?'

A housemaid said: 'Look at the blood,' and screamed with pleasurable excitement.

A footman said: 'Lor!'

The butler said, with a good deal more bravery in his manner than had been noticeable a few minutes earlier: 'Now then, this won't do!' and waved away underservants.

The efficient Mr Rupert Bateman said to George: 'Shall we get rid of some of these people, sir?'

Then they all took fresh breath.

'Incredible!' said George Lomax. 'Battle, what has *happened*?'

Battle gave him a look, and George's discreet habits assumed their usual sway.

'Now then,' he said, moving to the door, 'everyone go back to bed, please. There's been a—er—'

'A little accident,' said Superintendent Battle easily.

'A—er—an accident. I shall be much obliged if everyone will go back to bed.'

Everyone was clearly reluctant to do so.

'Lady Coote—please—'

'The poor boy,' said Lady Coote in a motherly fashion.

She rose from a kneeling position with great reluctance. And as she did so, Jimmy stirred and sat up.

Again Bundle opened her mouth, and again shut it without speaking. 'Right you are,' agreed Bill. 'Who'll take first duty?'

'Shall we spin for it?'

'Might as well.'

'All right. Here goes. Heads you first and I second. Tails, vice versa.'

Bill nodded. The coin spun in the air. Jimmy bent to look at it.

'Tails,' he said.

'Damn,' said Bill. 'You get first half and probably any fun that's going.'

'Oh, you never know,' said Jimmy. 'Criminals are very uncertain. What time shall I wake you? Three thirty?'

'That's about fair, I think.'

And now, at last, Bundle spoke:

'What about *me*? she asked.

'Nothing doing. You go to bed and sleep.'

'Oh!' said Bundle. 'That's not very exciting.'

'You never know,' said Jimmy kindly. 'You may be murdered in your sleep whilst Bill and I escape scot-free.'

'Well, there's always that possibility. Do you know, Jimmy, I don't half like the look of that Countess. I suspect her.'

'Nonsense,' cried Bill hotly. 'She's absolutely above suspicion.'

'How do you know?' retorted Bundle.

'Because I do. Why, one of the fellows at the Hungarian Embassy vouched for her.'

'Oh?' said Bundle, momentarily taken aback by his fervour.

'You girls are all the same,' grumbled Bill. 'Just because she's a jolly good-looking woman—'

Bundle was only too well acquainted with this unfair masculine line of argument.

'Well, don't you go and pour confidences into her shell-pink ear,' she remarked. 'I'm going to bed. I was bored stiff in that drawing-room and I'm not going back.'

She left the room. Bill looked at Jimmy.

'Good old Bundle,' he said. 'I was afraid we might have trouble with her. You know how keen she is to be in everything. I think the way she took it was just wonderful.'